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Volume XXXII Number 41; For the week Oct 9-15, 2007, released on Oct 8

• Editorial Office Living Media India Ltd. F-14/15, Connaught Place New Delhi 110001; Phones: 23315801-4;
Fax: 23316180; Cable: Livmedia, New Delhi

• Subscriptions: For assistance contact Customer Care India Today Group, A-61, Sector-57, Noida (UP)-201301;
Phones: Toll-free number: 1800 1800 100 (from BSNL/MTNL lines); (95120) 2479900 from Delhi and
Faridabad; (0120) 2479900 from Rest of India (Monday-Friday, 10 a.m.-6 p.m.); Fax: (0120) 4078080;
e-mail: ircare@indiatoday.com; Mumbai: 022-24444423-6; Fax: 24444358 • Sales: Direct all trade enquiries to
General Manager (Sales), Living Media India Limited, 201 Connaught Place, F-14, Middle Circle, Connaught Place,
New Delhi • Regd. Office: K-9 Connaught Circle, New Delhi 110001 • Import Offices: Trade Centre, 2nd Floor,
Kamala City, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Panel, Mumbai 400013; Phone: 24983355; Fax: 24982266 • Hamilton
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India Ltd., 18-35 Milestone, Delhi Mathura Road, Faridabad-121007, (Haryana), at Thomson Press India Ltd.,
A-9, Industrial Complex, Maraimalai Nagar, District Kancheepuram-603209, (Tamil Nadu), and at Thomson Press
India Ltd., Plot No. 3-5A, TTC Industrial Area, Thane, Belapur Road, Airoli, Navi Mumbai-400708, (Maharashtra).
Published at K-9, Connaught Circus, New Delhi-110001.

• India Today does not take responsibility for returning unsolicited publication material.

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courts and forums in Delhi/New Delhi only

In recent months, I have been amazed at how two actors, Shekhar Suman and Shah Rukh Khan, have magically transformed their bodies in a short span of time, enough to feature on the cover of abs-obsessed magazines like *Men's Health*. Surprisingly, neither of them is a spring chicken. They are both 40-plus. In the mid-1990s, it was a string of successful contestants at international beauty pageants who had heralded a beauty boom for women in India. Now it seems it is the turn of Indian men.

It is impossible to ignore the flood of images that celebrate the body beautiful among men. It is not just the Bollywood fraternity but the college student next door. Every man it seems, wants to show off his newly acquired six-pack. If you haven't got one, there are enough people to tell you how to achieve one. In the past, getting an ideal physique meant spending hours in a wrestling akhara and drinking gallons of milk but that prototype no longer holds true.

Lean and muscular is in and Indian men are doing everything to fit into that global mould. Gyms and health food stores have mushroomed, men are willing to pump weights, consume protein shakes, go on diets and try out cosmetic surgery procedures like muscle sculpting, facial rejuvenation, and abdominal etching. Body image appears to be as important to the Indian male as his bank balance.

There is an entire male beauty industry that caters to this growing demand and in turn, the consumers for the industry's products appear to be growing in number. The male beauty market is estimated to be worth Rs 6,950 crore and is growing at a rate of 11 per cent. The Indian man is bombarded with myriad ideas and images that centre around his appearance. At beauty salons, men have started outnumbering women. At the gym there is a physical trainer pushing new workouts or a muscle-building supplement, at the work place there is someone with well-defined deltoids showing beneath the business suit, and always, there is the temptation to go under the knife.

Our cover story this week was put together by Deputy Editor Damayanti Datta along with our nation-wide bureaus and Datta says, "Indian men are standing at the intersection of beauty, vanity and health." For the first time, men are finding themselves under pressure to conform to an ideal of male beauty being propagated by their cultural icons through an all-pervasive media. The consequences of this phenomenon will only be understood in a few years.

On a more serious subject, this week we also gathered the Board of India Today Economists (BITE) to discuss whether the Indian economy has been on steroids and if the effect is starting to wear off. What are the trends we can expect in the future? Like the men in our cover story, can the economy too get fit and healthy for sustainable high growth?

(Aroon Purie)

